

INTERVIEW | JAIRAM RAMESH

“If we do not change the National River Conservation Plan, the money will continue to get wasted”

Minister of State (independent charge) for Environment and Forests Jairam Ramesh hardly finds time to speak on rivers. Special Correspondent SHYAMLAL YADAV spoke to him at his office about the NRCP's state of affairs. Excerpts:

Q. Has the NRCP failed?

A. I will not say it has failed. The situation would have been even worse had the scheme not been there.

Q. What lessons have been learnt from this?

A. We are now focusing on basins while earlier it was town-specific. There is a National Green Tribunal Bill pending before Parliament.

Q. Does the NRCP need to be replaced/ redrafted?

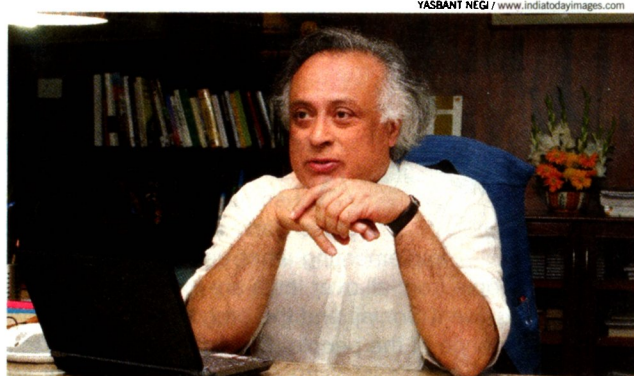
A. If we will not change it, the money will continue to get wasted.

Q. What other problems you faced while dealing with rivers' pollution?

A. In the case of the Bhagirathi, Alaknanda, Ganga, Tista and many other rivers where big dams are being constructed and hydel projects being installed, the water is going into tunnels. The NGRBA has discussed this. We will bring a policy within next two-three months. On new projects, we will go ahead only after planning it well.

Q. Some less important southern rivers have been included in the NRCP because of coalition politics.

A. I can only say that the politics will not be the basis of selection of rivers for the NRCP anymore. We will take



decisions only on the basis of need.

Q. Also, the financing formula for the NGRBA has not been finalised yet.

A. We proposed a 70/30 formula: 70 per cent from the Centre and 30 per cent from the state. Two states demanded that it should be wholly financed by the Centre. One state demanded that it should be 90/10. But in my view the 70/30 formula is alright. There must be participation of the states.

Q. Do you have any proposal to fix accountability for the implementing authorities and officials?

A. Yes, we are going to sign tripartite agreements among states, urban local bodies and the Centre in which the responsibilities will be clearly mentioned.

up an authority to monitor the slothful work only as late as in August 2008.

The Chambal in Rajasthan has not only suffered from being dirtied but is also the victim of a Centre-state clash over NRCP funding. In 1995, the state asked for Rs 30.53 crore but received only Rs 13.13 crore. A peeved state Government refused to spend any money on the project. A 2005 request was also turned down, but two years later the state agreed to cough up 30 per cent of a Rs 150-crore project to clean the river. Many project reports have been prepared regularly but there is no certainty when the government will start executing the work. Last week, Punjab Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal sought immediate release of Rs 302 crore from the Central Government for controlling pollution in the Sutlej and Ghaggar.

Once again, the focus of attention—and the funding—has been the Ganga and our self-ob-

sessed capital's much-abused Yamuna. In 2007, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had set up a high-powered committee for conservation and development of the Yamuna and a National Ganga River Basin Authority (NGRBA) in February 2009, being chairman for the both. The first meeting of the NGRBA recently resolved that the Ganga will be pollution-free by 2020 and will cost around Rs 15,000 crore. The World Bank recently agreed to provide an initial assistance of \$1 billion for NGRBA in the next four-five years.

No matter how well charted those presentations may be and those funds may sound, India's solution to its river pollution does not depend on money. What matters is the integrity of those in the business of implementation and the swiftness and conscientiousness of the NRCP.

with Ambreesh Mishra, Rohit Parihar, M.G. Radhakrishnan, Arvind Chhabra, Swati Mathur, Amitabh Srivastava, Farzand Ahmed and Adhi Valliappan